AN INTRODUCTION TO THE NT (D.A. CARSON & D. MOO)

CONTENT AND STRUCTURE

1 John

Like the Epistle to the Hebrews, 1 John does not exhibit any of the formal characteristics that are normally associated with the openings of letters written in Greek in the first century. Nevertheless, the personal references, the common ties the author shares with his readers, and the explicit historical referents (e.g., 2:19) make it clear that this writing was not intended to be an abstract paper, a mere brochure, or a tractate for all Christians everywhere. It was meant to be read as a pastoral letter to a congregation or to a number of congregations. There is something to be said for the view that its atypical form is a reflection of its author's intention to send it to several congregations along with an accompanying note personalizing each delivery: 2 John could be one such note and may be the only one that has come down to us (3 John does not qualify nearly so well).

The structure of 1 John is disputed, largely because John takes up a number of themes and keeps returning to them in slightly different connections. One of the best surveys of structure is by Marshall, though his own proposal—that no structure is believable because John probably connects his various sections by virtue of mere associations of ideas—sounds more haphazard than the flow of the epistle will allow. Although most see between the prologue (1:1–4) and the conclusion (5:14–21) two large sections (1:5–2:29; 3:1–5:13) broken down in various ways, Schnackenburg's suggestion of three divisions has much to commend it: the first treats fellowship with God as walking in the light (1:5–2:17), the second deals directly with the present situation of the church or churches to which John addresses himself (2:18–3:24), and the third divides those who belong to God from the "world" by the tests laid out in the epistle (4:1–5:12). Virtually all sides agree that John lays down three tests: (1) true believers must believe that Jesus truly is the Christ come in the flesh, and this belief must work itself out in (2) righteousness and (3) love.

2 and 3 John

It is widely agreed that these two short epistles bear the form of letters. Ostensibly written to "the lady chosen by God and to her children," 2 John is directed to another congregation—whether to a house church within the same city or to the church of another city is unclear—to warn against the dangers inherent in traveling preachers, some of whom are "deceivers, who do not acknowledge Jesus Christ as coming in the flesh" (7). But even here, John insists that true believers walk not only in the truth but in transparent love for one another, in line with the command "you have heard from the beginning" (6). This message occupies the central section (4–11) between the introduction (1–3) and the conclusion (12–13).

By contrast with 2 John, which mentions no one by name except Jesus Christ, 3 John is addressed to Gaius about the activities of Diotrephes, who not only "loves to be first" (9) but has become so powerful that he is even refusing the emissaries of the writer, ejecting from the church those who take a softer line. John encourages Gaius (who may have belonged to the church where Diotrephes held court) to follow instead the example of Demetrius and warns that he is coming to expose Diotrephes.

AUTHOR

The external evidence is consistent and can be briefly stated. Possible allusions are found in many of the documents from the end of the first century and the first half of the second century. The most likely are the following: (1) Clement of Rome describes God's elect people as being "perfected in love" (*1 Clem*. 49:5; 50:3, c. A.D. 96; cf. 1 John 2:5; 4:12, 17–18); (2) the *Didache* (estimated date ranges from 90 to 120) has

something similar (10:5), a parallel made more impressive in this case by the mention in the next verse of the world passing away (10:6; cf. 1 John 2:17); (3) the *Epistle of Barnabas* (c. 130) speaks of Jesus as "the Son of God come in the flesh" (5:9–11; 12:10; cf. 1 John 4:2; 2 John 7); (4) Polycarp warns against deceiving false brothers in these terms: "For everyone who does not confess Jesus Christ to have come in the flesh is Antichrist" (*Phil.* 7:1, c. 135), surely dependent on 2 John 7 and 1 John 4:2–3; cf. 1 John 2:22. Numerous other allusions are proposed, most of them less plausible than these.

However, the first author to refer specifically to a Johannine epistle as the work of John is Papias of Hierapolis in the middle of the second century, who, according to Eusebius (*H.E.* 3.39.17), "used testimonies drawn from the former Epistle of John." It is important to note that "former" is Eusebius's word, not Papias's; one cannot deduce from it that Papias knew of more than one Johannine epistle. By the time of Irenaeus (c. A.D. 180), at least the first and second epistles are explicitly attributed to John, the disciple of the Lord and the author of the fourth gospel (*Adv. Haer.* 3.16.18). Writing at about the same time, Clement of Alexandria knows of more than one Johannine epistle, since he refers to "the greater epistle" and ascribes it to the apostle John (see *Strom*. 2.15.66; cf. 3.4.32; 3.5.42; 4.16.100). Thereafter the evidence becomes plentiful.

The external evidence for 2 and 3 John is not as strong as for 1 John, partly owing to the fact that they are so brief and somewhat less theologically focused and thus unlikely to be quoted so often. We have already noted that 2 John is linked with 1 John by Irenaeus and that Clement knows of more than one Johannine epistle. So far as our records go, it is Origen (d. A.D. 253) who first mentions all three epistles, but according to Eusebius (*H.E.* 6.25.10), he does so in part to acknowledge that not everyone accepted the authenticity of 2 and 3 John. Origen's pupil Dionysius of Alexandria (d. 265) insisted that John the apostle wrote the fourth gospel and 1 John (but not Revelation) and knew about 2 and 3 John (see further the section "Adoption into the Canon" below). Never is any of the three Johannine epistles attributed to anyone other than John the son of Zebedee.

As for the internal evidence, nothing in any of the Johannine Epistles points unambiguously to a specific author. All the arguments finally turn on the relation of these epistles to the fourth gospel. Methodologically, it is easiest first to deal with the relation of 1 John to the gospel, and then to consider the relation of 2 John and 3 John to 1 John.

A superficial reading of the fourth gospel and 1 John reveals many striking similarities in theme, vocabulary, and syntax. The same stark polarities prevail: light and darkness, life and death, truth and falsehood, love and hate—with no third alternative. The same relatively simple syntax is found in both, combined with a marked penchant for parallelism. Poythress has shown that the prevalence of asyndeton and the relative infrequency of intersentence conjunctions in both documents argue for the same author. Stott has demonstrated that the same "scheme of salvation" pervades both 1 John and the fourth gospel. To offer but a few examples: In our unredeemed state we are "of the devil," who has sinned and lied and murdered "from the beginning" (1 John 3:8/John 8:44); we are "from the world" (2:16; 4:5/8:23; 15:19); therefore, we "sin" (3:4/8:34) and "have" sin (1:8/9:41), "walk in the darkness" (1:6; 2:11/8:12; 12:35), and are "dead" (3:14/5:25). God loved us and sent his Son to be "the Savior of the world" (4:14/4:42) so that "we might live" (4:9/3:16). Believing in him or in his "name" (5:13/1:12), we pass from death to life (3:14/5:24). We "have life" (5:11, 12/3:15, 36; 20:31), for life is in the Son of God (5:11–12/1:4; 14:6). This is what it means to be "born of God" (2:29; 3:9; 5:4, 18/1:13). There is much more of the same.

Those who argue for a different author for the two documents usually appeal to three kinds of phenomena.

1. There are subtle but significant differences between John and 1 John in both doctrine and wording, even when they are formally parallel. For instance, it is commonly argued that only in John is the λόγος (*logos*, "Word") personal (see John 1:1, 14); in 1 John 1:1–4, the "word" is the "word of life," and it is the life that is personal. In the fourth gospel, the Holy Spirit is the παράκλητος (*paraklētos*, "Paraclete" or "Counselor," John 14–16); in 1 John 2:1, it is Jesus himself. John affirms that "God is Spirit"; 1 John says, rather, that he is light (1:5) and love (4:8, 16). In the fourth gospel, the death of Jesus is presented as his being "lifted up" and "glorified"; in the epistle, the purpose of Jesus' death is propitiatory (2:2; 4:10). It is often argued that in the fourth gospel the eschatology is profoundly "realized" (i.e., people enjoy eternal life already), while in 1 John much more place is given to Jesus' future, personal coming (2:28; 3:2; 4:17).

On close examination, these and similar objections carry little weight. It is true that the prologue to the fourth gospel uses λόγος *(logos)* to refer to the pre-incarnate Son of God, but it uses the same word numerous times throughout the gospel with its more common meaning of "message" (e.g., 8:31), and some scholars think that even in 1 John the personal usage has not disappeared (i.e., they understand the text to say that it is the "word of life," not the "life," that has appeared). That Jesus should be called the παράκλητος *(parakletos)* in 1 John is scarcely surprising, for Jesus in John insists he is sending *another* Paraclete (John 14:16): one could surely argue common authorship from this, rather than disparate authorship. The suggestion that the one who wrote that God is spirit is unlikely to have written that he is light and love is almost silly on the face of it. If the fourth gospel looks at Jesus' death as a "lifting up" and a "glorification," it is partly because it is focusing on the historical Jesus and partly because it is intent on showing that the cross was not the defeat that some Jews thought it was. If 1 John casts Jesus' death in terms of its propitiatory significance, that owes much to his polemical purpose: he is concerned to show that sin has serious effects, and the only way to remove those effects is by the provision that God himself has made. In any case, the presentation of Jesus' death in the fourth gospel is not univocal: other themes intrude there and overlap with those of 1 John (see John 1:29; 3:14–16, 36; 6:51; 10:11, 15; 11:49–52; etc.). We should speak of complementarity of vision and thought, of differentiation in application, not of mutual contradiction. Finally, although the eschatological emphases of the two books are not identical, the complementary truth is also found in both books: the fourth gospel reserves space for futurist eschatology (5:28–29; 6:39–40, 44, 54; 11:24–26; 12:48; 14:3), while 1 John insists that those who believe may have confidence that they experience eternal life as a present possession.

2. There are words and expressions in John's gospel not found in 1 John, and vice versa (see Brooke's commentary for the lists). Today most scholars acknowledge that nothing decisive can be based on these lists. The divergent vocabularies enjoy greater similarity than those of, say, Luke and Acts, known to come from the same pen, or of Ephesians and Colossians, or of 1 Timothy and Titus. "The variations in phrase suggest common authorship rather than servile, or even intelligent, copying."

3. Those who are persuaded that a "Johannine School" accounts for the Johannine corpus of the New Testament are inclined to see different members of the "school" writing different parts of the corpus (i.e., the Gospel of John, the Johannine Epistles, and Revelation). Indeed, the "we" who apparently attest the reliability of the author of the fourth gospel (at least on one reading of John 21:24) might be the same "we" that stands behind 1 John (e.g., 1 John 1:1–5). But a great deal is being made to ride on a "Johannine School" whose existence is not more certain than a number of questionable inferences (on which see below) and on the term "we," which experience in reading the New Testament shows can turn up in highly diverse contexts and with even more diverse referents.

Although a few scholars have argued that 2 John and 3 John were written by a person other than the one who wrote 1 John, not many have been persuaded by them. The links of both vocabulary and theme are too many (granted the brevity of the second and third epistles) to justify such skepticism (e.g., "Jesus

Christ has come in the flesh" [2 John 7/1 John 4:2]; "deceiver" and "antichrist" [2 John 7/1 John 2:22]; those who love and do good show that they are "from God" [3 John 11/1 John 3:10; 4:4, 7]).

More difficult to explain, on the traditional view, is why the author of 2 John and 3 John should refer to himself as ὁ πρεσβύτερος (*ho presbyteros*, "the elder"). This certainly does not give justification to the position of Eusebius, and of many modern scholars who have followed him, who argue that the fourth gospel and the Johannine Epistles were written, not by John the apostle, but by John the elder (see discussion in the section "Author" in chap. 6). Note, however, that there is nothing anomalous about an apostle designating himself as an elder (1 Pet. 5:1; cf. Papias, in the discussion just reported). Furthermore, the term "elder" can refer to an old man (see Philem. 9, using the cognate term πρεσβύτερος [*presbytēs*]). If the author is John the son of Zebedee, the last of the apostles, it is not inappropriate for him to make a dual allusion. This interpretation may be strengthened by observing the article: John refers to himself as "*the* elder." He could scarcely refer to himself as "the apostle": that would surely sound a trifle pompous, even if he was the last of the Twelve to survive. He was simply *an* apostle (note the usage of Paul in Rom. 1:1, and of Peter in 1 Peter 1:1). But he could be *the* elder in the Ephesus region, precisely because he was not just an ordinary elder.

Two other factors argue for apostolic authorship.

1. Although in most of the "we" passages in the Johannine Epistles the pronoun includes the Christian readers and is set over against the "they" of the "world" (i.e., non-Christians, including heretics—e.g., 2:3; 3:2, 11; 4:19), in a few passages the most reasonable exegesis suggests that the "we" refers to the author and his fellow eyewitnesses in contrast to the "you" of the Christian readers. This is particularly true in 1:1, 3; 4:14; 5:6–7. Despite vigorous protests to the contrary, in these passages the author distinguishes himself as writer from his readers, as eyewitness from second-generation believers, and as authoritative teacher from those who are being taught.

2. The latter distinction (between authoritative teacher and those being taught) deserves expansion. It is not simply the sweep and tone of the writer's authority that is at issue, though that is impressive (e.g., 2:1–2, 8, 15, 17, 23, 28; 3:6, 9; 4:1, 8, 16; 5:21), not least when he brands certain people as liars, deceivers, and antichrists (cf. Gal. 1:8, 9). Rather, it is that he does so *across congregations* (2 and 3 John). Indeed, it is this fact that prompts Käsemann to argue that the author of the Johannine Epistles was not the apostle John but the first of what became monarchical bishops, leading directly to the stance of Ignatius that the church exists where the bishop is. That means, of course, that it is Diotrephes who is trying to preserve the more primitive pattern of local church autonomy. Few have agreed with Käsemann; the more obvious motive for Diotrephes' power play is simply that he loved to be first (3 John 9)—a problem not unknown in either the ancient church (see 2 Cor. 10–13) or the modern. But that means that the most obvious explanation for this cross-congregational authority is that the author of these epistles was an apostle, since elders per se did not, so far as we know, enjoy such authority.

Almost inevitably, the most fundamental reasons advanced today for rejecting Johannine authorship of these epistles turn, not on the hard evidence or on source theories that have almost universally been abandoned, but on reconstructions of the development of the Johannine "circle" or "community" or "school." This reconstruction exercises such controlling power in contemporary discussion that the possibility of apostolic authorship is prematurely ruled out in favor of a document refracting the light from community beliefs. These matters are treated at some length in chapter 6 above on the fourth gospel, and they also have a bearing on our understanding of the purpose of these epistles (see the section "Purpose" below).

PROVENANCE

Whether one thinks in terms of apostolic authorship or of a Johannine school, the most likely provenance is Ephesus. The evidence that John the son of Zebedee (and for that matter Philip the evangelist and his daughters) moved to Ephesus at the time of the Jewish War (A.D. 66–70) and ultimately died there is not overwhelming, but it is consistent. It depends in large part on the witness of Polycrates, bishop of Ephesus, writing to Victor, bishop of Rome, c. 190 (so Eusebius, *H.E.* 3.31.3; 5.24.2), and the witness of Irenaeus (*Adv. Haer.* 3.1.1), who knew both Papias and Polycarp. Several witnesses could also point to the tombs of Philip and his daughters and of the beloved disciple (see discussion in chaps. 6 and 24).

Those who judge the external evidence to be late and unreliable deny any connection with Ephesus and postulate other centers, largely on the basis of conceptual links with literature thought to come from those centers. Thus, on the grounds that the Johannine Epistles are tied in some way to the fourth gospel and that the gospel shares some conceptual links with *Odes of Solomon*, thought to have originated in Syria, Kümmel cautiously postulates Syria. Methodologically, this approach appears to be far too cavalier with specific historical witnesses and far too trusting of our ability to establish the closest conceptual links (not to mention our utter ignorance of how far a document such as the *Odes of Solomon* circulated toward the end of the first century).

DATE

The date of the Johannine Epistles is entirely bound up with the date of the fourth gospel and their relationship to it. As we have seen, although a few date the Gospel of John before A.D. 70, and a majority assign it to the last decade of the first century, we have cautiously suggested 80–85. The question to be posed, then, is whether the epistles were written before or after the gospel.

Certainty is impossible; the decision depends, finally, on one's understanding of the respective purposes of the fourth gospel and of the Johannine Epistles. We will argue that the epistles, unlike the gospel, were written in part to establish and encourage the faith of Christians in the wake of rising controversy over proto-Gnosticism (see the section "Purpose" below). Since this movement was on the ascendancy at the end of the first century (though it did not reach full flowering until well into the second century), it seems best to date the epistles *after* the fourth gospel. This judgment is confirmed by the evidence that suggests that at least some of the gnostic heretics were using the fourth gospel for their own purposes: certainly John was a favorite of gnostics in the second century (though John 1:14, "the Word became flesh," was ultimately destructive of their beliefs). Probably, therefore, some time elapsed between the publication of the fourth gospel and that of the epistles, enough at least to allow what John perceives to be the improper use of his earlier work to gain enough steam to cause schism in the church (see 1 John 2:19). Constrained at the other end by apparent allusions to 1 John in some of the subapostolic fathers, it appears best to date the Johannine epistles to the early 90s.

One recent commentator argues that 2 and 3 John were written around A.D. 100, and possibly as late as 130, with 1 John and the Gospel of John coming not later than the middle of the second century. Quite apart from the highly conjectural reconstructions in which he engages, he must question the dating of P52, which contains a portion of John 18 and is usually dated to 125: he assigns this and other early evidence "to the realm of the creation of pious legends," assigning them to A.D. 200 or even later. The patristic evidence is handled with similar aplomb. Although one wants to admire independent judgment, it is difficult to be quite so positive about technically sophisticated scholarship that discounts so much of the evidence.

DESTINATION

First John mentions no addressee and preserves no specific greetings, formal thanksgiving, or any of the other formal touches that normally characterize a first-century letter. The second epistle is addressed to "the lady chosen by God and to her children," almost certainly not a respected Christian matron and her family but a local congregation. It can scarcely be thought that this epistle is directed to the universal church, since it reports greetings from "the children of your sister, who is chosen by God" (2 John 13), which must be understood to be salutations from another congregation: the universal church has no sister. Even so, it is just possible that the author chose this form of address not only for its symbolic connections but also because it was flexible enough to be used with respect to *several* congregations. The third epistle is addressed to an individual, Gaius by name, not to be associated with Gaius of Corinth (1 Cor. 1:14; Rom. 16:23) or Gaius of Macedonia (Acts 19:29), and probably not Gaius of Derbe (Acts 20:4)—though a fourth-century document, the *Apostolic Constitutions* (7.46.9), makes this latter connection. The document is late, and "Gaius" was an exceedingly common name in the Roman Empire.

The geographic destination cannot be more than an inference from what is reconstructed of the documents' provenance. Probably, therefore, these epistles were sent to churches (and an individual) somewhere in the Ephesus area, including, perhaps, the territory spanned by the seven churches of Revelation 2–3.

PURPOSE

A few scholars have argued that 1 John is pastoral and not polemical, that there is no need to reconstruct a group of heretics or secessionists. The first epistle was written to foster Christian assurance and to ward off possible developments in the community's theology that could have ultimately led to schism; or, if there was trouble, it was caused by nothing more than the undisciplined exercise of prophetic gifts.

Although John does intend to edify his readers, most scholars rightly reject this view as an inadequate explanation of the evidence. Some believers have already seceded (1 John 2:18–19), and John is writing to warn his readers about false teachers who are actively trying to deceive them (2:26). Paul's prophecy to the Ephesian elders (Acts 20:29–30), renewed to Timothy (2 Tim. 3:1–7; 4:3–4), was coming true: "savage wolves" were rending the flock, and John labels them "false prophets" (1 John 4:1), "deceivers" (2 John 7), and "antichrists" (1 John 2:18; 4:3; 2 John 7). Probably their secession owed much to their failure to convert more of the congregation(s) to which they once belonged (1 John 2:18–19): many Christians by their adherence to the truth had "overcome them" (1 John 4:4). Still, John finds he must reassure the faithful and explain in straightforward terms the differences between the two groups and thereby give them grounds for their own assurance and confidence before God (1 John 5:13) at a time when they were being made to feel inferior and spiritually threatened.

The differences between John's readers and John's opponents are substantial. The secessionists denied that Jesus was the Christ (2:22)—not apparently meaning that they disbelieved that Jesus was the Messiah of Old Testament expectation, but that the human Jesus really was the Christ, the Son (2:23; 4:15; 2 John 9). They denied that Christ had come in the flesh (4:2; 2 John 7). Judging by 1 John 1:6–10, they also denied that they were in any sense dominated by or even subject to sin: it did not inhere in their nature, display itself in their behavior, or hinder their fellowship with God. Meanwhile their own conduct was so haughty, loveless, and schismatic that they denied the very gospel they claimed that only they understood, prompting some of the more hesitant amongst those left behind to wonder at times if they had the Spirit at all (see 2:26–27).

What, then, could account for this matrix of errors? Probably the majority of contemporary commentators still hold that the external evidence demands that we postulate one of three movements:

Gnosticism. This theosophical potpourri was anchored in neoplatonic dualism, which fostered a dichotomy between matter (evil) and spirit (good). In the classic gnostic myth that comes down to us from third-century sources, there is an ultimate Father from whom a variety of spiritual beings emanate. One of these, Wisdom, tries to act independently from another, Thought, and unintentionally produces a misshapen being, Wisdom's son Ialdabaoth, who steals enough of her power to become the creator of the spiritual powers who rule this world and with whose help the physical universe, including Adam and Eve, comes into being. The biblical stories are then retold to accommodate the changes. The fall narrative (Gen. 3), for instance, becomes an attempt to impart true knowledge (*gnosis*) to those imprisoned in evil matter by the action of their evil creator. Adam ultimately begets Seth, who receives some pure spirit. This sets up a dichotomy in the human race: some have their origins in this spirit-life; others are nothing but matter. Later versions of the myth tell of a gnostic redeemer who explains their origins to the "elect" (i.e., not to those who are sovereignly chosen by God, but to those who are chosen by virtue of their possession of spirit-life and who therefore have the capacity to receive this "knowledge," thereby liberating them). The structure of gnostic myths varies considerably. Valentinus, in the second century, taught that the Godhead is made up of thirty "aeons," regarded as male and female pairs. Among them, Intellect and Truth produced Word and Life, who in turn produced Man and Church. Whatever the precise structure, some scholars argue that the heretics presupposed by 1 and 2 John have been influenced by Gnosticism and are concerned with deliverance from the flesh by the acquisition of knowledge.

Docetism. More particularly, a branch of Gnosticism known as Docetism (from δοκέω [*dokeō*], "it seems") applied the same reasoning so as to reject the incarnation. Docetism asked, How can a spirit-being, "Christ" or the "Son of God," good by definition, actually become flesh, which is evil by definition? Although such a spirit-being may temporarily *assume* it, it could never *become* it. Docetists so misconceived the true locus of evil that they fell into sin and puffed themselves up with gnostic pride.

The heresy of Cerinthus. No less commonly, appeal is made to Cerinthus, about whom we learn chiefly from Irenaeus and Eusebius. Eusebius, for instance, preserves Polycarp's report that John the apostle fled the bathhouse in Ephesus when he found that Cerinthus was in it, on the ground that God could at any time reach down and destroy this "enemy of the truth" (*H.E.* 3.3.4; cf. 3.28.6; 4.14.6). Irenaeus gives an account of Cerinthus's heretical views (*Adv. Haer.* 1.16.1; 3.2.1, 7, 8), which severed the man Jesus from the divine Christ (or from the Spirit, according to Epiphanius's report of the heresy [*Haer.* 28.1]). The Christ (or the Spirit) came upon Jesus at his baptism and left him to suffer alone on the cross (since the Christ/Spirit himself is impassible).

The explanatory power of these proposed backgrounds is considerable, but caution must be exercised. For example, Marshall points out that some of what we know about Cerinthus (e.g., his belief that Jesus was the son of an inferior creator-god) is not reflected in the Johannine Epistles, while some of what the epistles oppose (e.g., the claim to sinlessness) is not known to have been associated with Cerinthus. Schnackenburg, who favors a background in Docetism of the kind opposed by Ignatius a mere decade or two later (e.g., *Smyr.* 1–3; *Magn.* 11; *Trall.* 9–10), nevertheless acknowledges that there are critical differences: for example, the Docetists opposed by Ignatius are tied to Jewish rites and beliefs, of which there are no traces in the Johannine Epistles.

Above all, the dates of Gnosticism itself are disputed. Full-blown Gnosticism is almost certainly an amalgam of Jewish, Christian, and pagan deviations, an amorphous movement whose flowering is not only later than the New Testament but is also so diverse in its manifestations that very few generalizations can be made. The most plausible conclusion is that the movement was gaining strength when John wrote his epistles, and some of the contours of the particular form it took in this case can be hesitantly delineated from these letters. Doubtless this form cannot be precisely identified with any of the manifestations that

have come down to us independently. The point is that rather few have been preserved for us, and the most we can say is that so far as the epistles of John go, the discernible errors and abysmal practices that are being opposed have much in common with the Docetism and Cerinthianism of which we know all too little.

Some contemporary scholars, however, pay little attention to this external evidence and go down one of two other tracks. Some think that the explanation of 1 John lies in its rhetoric, which, rightly understood, does not demand that we invest too much time seeking opponents: the rhetoric is self-justifying, not polemical. (We briefly assess some of this work below under "Recent Study.") Others seek to trace out divergent streams of "Johannine Christianity," largely by establishing trajectories from the fourth gospel (or from perceived distinguishable traditions in the fourth gospel) to a complex situation that can be retrieved from the Johannine Epistles. Virtually all of these scholars exhibit far more sympathy for John's opponents than John did, and sometimes more for the opponents than for John himself.

Smalley, who at least is sympathetic to the epistles, nevertheless insists that distinctions between heresy and orthodoxy have not yet been made at this period in the church's life—an extraordinary judgment when Paul was making them almost half a century earlier (see Gal. 1:8–9; 2 Cor. 11:4; see further John 14:6; Acts 4:12). Houlden thinks the fourth gospel is adventurous and speculative and judges that the "dissidents" simply wanted to go a little farther in the same direction, while the epistles are a conservative "rearguard action" to reassert traditional doctrine. Smalley postulates three groups—one that denies Jesus' humanity, another that denies Jesus' deity, and a group of seceders (who may have overlapped with the others)—all quite apart from the traditionalists.

Brown engages in considerable speculation and uncontrolled inferences to tease out the contours of two groups, divided, not in their acceptance of the authority of the fourth gospel, but in its interpretation. One group seceded; the other group produced at least 1 John and 2 John; and the two groups disagreed fundamentally, especially in the areas of Christology, ethics, eschatology, and pneumatology (with his commentary primarily focusing on the first two). Brown does not think it is possible for the historian to judge which group understood the fourth gospel correctly. Because of this stance, he argues, for instance, that the secessionists did not deny the humanity of Jesus (since they held John 1:14 to be authoritative) but denied that the humanity of Jesus was significant for revelation or salvation. Perhaps—but the texts do not say so, and a great deal is made to rest on the postulate that both sides adopted the fourth gospel. Brown thinks that in the aftermath of the struggle the "secessionists" (he cannot think of them as heretics) drifted off into the later "heretical" movements (Cerinthianism, Montanism, Docetism, etc.), while those remaining "were swallowed up by the 'Great Church.' "

Detailed evaluation is not possible in short compass. Methodologically, the heart of the problem is the heaping up of merely possible inferences (see discussion in chap. 6 and below in "The Johannine Epistles in Recent Study") and the too-ready distancing from the external sources. It still seems best to conclude that John is combating proto-Gnosticism, an embryonic Docetism or Cerinthianism that has already divided Christians. Over against the emphases of his opponents—emphases that he frankly aligns with all that is non-Christian—John stresses the truth that Jesus is Christ come in the flesh and that genuine belief in this Jesus works itself out in obedience to the commands of God and in love for God's people.

If this is approximately correct, the purpose of 2 John is primarily to warn a congregation or house church against admitting traveling teachers who espouse such false teaching. Although many have attempted to find similar heresy behind 3 John (whether in Diotrephes or in the writer!), the epistle itself betrays no such aberrations and is perhaps nothing other than an apostolic warning against someone who is attempting to appropriate all local authority. Even so, we would have to conclude that this was taking place against the background established by the other two epistles. We might therefore speculate that

Diotrephes was using the danger of heresy to build his own power base. But it is hard to imagine that he himself is a heretic, or John would surely have denounced him for it.

TEXT

The detailed work of Richards, supplemented marginally by the work of Amphoux, has shown that in all probability the text of the Johannine Epistles is supported by three text types—Alexandrian (with three subgroups), Byzantine (seven subgroups), and Mixed (three subgroups)—not two or four, as some have argued.

Only a few passages contain variants of substantial exegetical significance, the most notorious being the addition of the "Trinitarian witnesses" at 1 John 5:7–8a: "For there are three that bear record in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost: and these three are one. And there are three that bear witness in earth" (KJV). This is certainly a gloss. It is found in no Greek manuscript before the fourteenth century, except for one eleventh- and one twelfth-century manuscript, where the words have been added in the margin by a much later hand. None of the early Greek fathers quotes the words, and it is quite certain that had they known of them, they would have used them in the ancient Trinitarian debates. None of the ancient versions supports the gloss, including the early editions of the (Latin) Vulgate. The words first appear in a fourth-century Latin treatise (not a biblical manuscript), after which some Latin fathers start to use them.

ADOPTION INTO THE CANON

The earliest witnesses to the Johannine Epistles have already been surveyed. The first mention of all three epistles is in a context that reports at least some hesitation as to the suitability of 2 and 3 John for inclusion in the canon: Origen (c. A.D. 231) writes that John "left an epistle of a very few lines and, it may be, a second and a third, for not all say that these [i.e., the second and the third] are genuine" (quoted by Eusebius, *H.E.* 6.25.10). Eusebius (c. 325) includes 1 John among the *homologoumena*, or acknowledged books, but places 2 and 3 John among the *antilegomena*, the disputed books (*H.E.* 3.25.2–3)—though he says they are "well known and acknowledged by most," whether they were written by John the apostle or by "another of the same name" (certainly referring to the "John the elder" theory, which depends at least in part on his misreading of Papias; see the section "Author" in chap. 6). He himself is persuaded that all three Johannine Epistles were written by John the apostle (*H.E.* 6.25.10). The Muratorian Canon refers to two epistles by John, but probably 1 and 2 John are in mind, not 2 and 3 John.

First John belongs to a group of New Testament epistles often called catholic, or general, because they are not addressed to a specific community or individual. Origen applies the term "catholic" to 1 John (*Comm. on Matt*. 17.19) and his disciple Dionysius, bishop of Alexandria, speaks of 1 John as John's "catholic epistle," possibly in contrast to 2 and 3 John (*H.E.* 7.25.7, 10). A little later, 2 and 3 John were reckoned among the seven catholic epistles (James, 1–2 Peter, 1–3 John, Jude—so Eusebius, *H.E.* 2.23.25), where "catholic" has come to mean almost "canonical"—that is, canonical in addition to the canonical epistles of Paul. All three Johannine Epistles are included in Athanasius's list of twenty-seven New Testament books (A.D. 367) and in the lists approved by the Councils of Hippo (393) and of Carthage (397). The Peshitta included 1 John but not 2 and 3 John. Not until the next century, with the publication of the Philoxenian version (508), were the two shorter epistles (along with 2 Peter, Jude, and Revelation, which had also been omitted) included in a Syriac New Testament. In Reformation times, debates over the authorship of 2 and 3 John were again raised, both on the Roman Catholic side (Cajetan) and in the humanist tradition represented by Erasmus, but not over their canonicity.

1, 2, AND 3 JOHN IN RECENT STUDY

With few exceptions (though they are notable), the driving force behind many studies of the Johannine Epistles until about a decade ago was the attempt to delineate the contours—more, the trajectories of the changing contours—of the Johannine community. We have already argued that this is a mistake. It is not that nothing profitable can be said about the communities to which the epistles were sent; rather, it is that merely possible inferences regarding those communities must not be allowed to control the exegesis. Many of the criticisms Brevard Childs levels against Brown could rightly be applied to a number of modern commentaries. According to Childs, Brown's exegesis of the Johannine Epistles is made to rest so entirely on his detailed reconstructions of his opponents, including not only their theology but their motives, that the edifice becomes precariously speculative. Since Brown argues that the competing perspectives of the epistles and of the secessionists turn on different interpretations of the fourth gospel, at every point he attempts to reconstruct the origin of each doctrinal stance and the riposte; but "what purports to be an historical investigation is actually an exercise in creative imagination with very few historical controls." Every clause in the text of 1 John is historicized—not simply passages that call for it (e.g., 2:19). The result is a flattening of exegesis in which virtually every passage serves exclusively as polemic, and entire ranges of exegetical options are foreclosed; the necessary circularity in all historical reconstructions is in danger of becoming vicious. For instance, the sin unto death (5:16–17) is simply identified with the sin of the secessionists. There is a continuing need for treatments of the Johannine Epistles that are less speculative in their handling of historical reconstructions and more profound in their reflection on theological, canonical connections.

While this focus on the history and profile of the Johannine community shows no sign of abating, the last decade or so has nevertheless witnessed a broadening of research foci. The current interest in the literary and rhetorical character of New Testament texts has found its exponents in the study of the Johannine Epistles. We noted above that some of this emphasis on rhetoric leads some scholars to attempt a reading of 1 John that is depolemicized (see n. 27). Although Griffith does not put quite so much emphasis on the function of rhetoric, his conclusions are similar: he argues that 1 John is not in the least a polemical book, but simply a hortative treatise: John is not fighting anyone, but is exhorting people to persevere in the gospel, largely against the kind of Jewish inroads (he argues) that stand behind debates in Galatians. That someone can seriously argue such a case reminds us how many of our reconstructions are built on disputable inferences, and it demands that we check the foundations again. In this instance, however, it is difficult to deny a polemical thrust to this first epistle, in the light of 2:18–19, and its implications for the surrounding verses. And the view that the danger against which John is warning is a return to Judaism, rather than the threat of proto-Gnosticism, strikes us as historically odd: it probes very little into the texture of the Greco-Roman world, and it does not explain why 1 John is in substance and emphasis so very different from books like Galatians and Hebrews, where something rather more akin to the dangers Griffith sees are actually being confronted. Other slightly "maverick" positions are worth weighing. In chapter 17 (on the Pastoral Epistles), we noted the contribution of R. Alastair Campbell, whose provocative work on "elders" is equally applicable (and disputable) with reference to 2 John and 3 John.

THE CONTRIBUTION OF THE JOHANNINE EPISTLES

Taken together, the Epistles of John stand poised as a demonstration of the critical importance of testing all attempts to rearticulate the gospel by the immutables of the gospel revelation. Doubtless John's opponents saw themselves as being on the leading edge of Christian reflection (2 John 9). By contrast, John reverts to what was "from the beginning," to the testimony of the first eyewitnesses, to incontrovertible christological givens, to the perennial newness of the "old" command to love one another, to the irrefragable connection

between genuine faith and obedience. This stance has a bearing on what teachings a church will listen to (2 John). At the practical level, whether heresy stands behind 3 John or not, this holistic vision insists that there is no place for petty gurus in the church who will not bow to apostolic admonition and authority.

The Johannine Epistles make an important contribution to the doctrine of assurance (see 1 John 5:13). If other New Testament writings make it clear that the objective grounds of our confidence before God are in Christ and his death and resurrection on our behalf, such that Christian assurance is not much more than a concomitant of genuine faith, these epistles insist that a distinction must be made between genuine and spurious faith. Spurious faith does not have the right to assurance before God; genuine faith can be authenticated not only by the validity of its object (in this case, the belief that Jesus is Christ come in the flesh) but also by the transformation it effects in the individual: genuine Christians learn to love one another and obey the truth. Christian assurance is not, for John, an abstract good; it is intimately tied to a continuing and transforming relationship with the covenant God, who has revealed himself in Jesus Christ.

The Johannine Epistles open an unrivaled window onto at least one part of the New Testament church toward the end of the apostolic age. Though their treatment of certain subjects is distinctive, here there is measured but emphatic emphasis on eternal life that was with the Father and has been mediated by the Son (1 John 1:2); on the Son's atonement (2:1–2; 3:8; 4:10; 5:6); and on the Holy Spirit (2:20–27; 3:24–4:6). These documents afford us the opportunity to draw some lines, however hesitantly, between the church as reflected in the earliest writings of the New Testament and the church at the end of the first century, and constitute the sinews that stretch out toward the subapostolic fathers and the patristic era.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

- Chr. B. **Amphoux**, "Note sur le classement des manuscrits grecs de 1 Jean," *RHPR* 61 (1981): 125–35
- John **Bogaert**, *Orthodox and Heretical Perfectionism*, SBLDS 33 (Missoula: SP, 1977)
- Pierre **Bonnard**, *Les épîtres johanniques*, CNT (Geneva: Labor & Fides, 1983)
- A. E. **Brooke**, *A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Johannine Epistles*, ICC (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1912)
- Raymond E. **Brown**, *The Epistles of John*, AB 30 (Garden City: Doubleday, 1982)
- F. **Büchsel**, *Die Johannesbriefe*, THNT (Leipzig: Deichert, 1933)
- Rudolf **Bultmann**, *The Johannine Epistles*, ET Hermeneia (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1973)
- G. M. **Burge**, *The Anointed Community: The Holy Spirit in the Johannine Tradition* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1987)
- R. Alan **Culpepper**, *The Gospel and Letters of John*, IBT (Nashville: Abingdon Press, 1998)
- C. H. **Dodd**, *The Johannine Epistles*, MNTC (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1946)
- Ruth B. **Edwards**, *The Johannine Epistles*, NTG (Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 1996)
- Kenneth **Grayston**, *The Johannine Epistles*, NCB (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1984)
- Terry **Griffith**, *Keep Yourselves from Idols: A New Look at 1 John*, JSNTSup 233 (Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 2002)
- Martin **Hengel**, *The Johannine Question* (London: SCM, 1989)

Carson, D. A., & Moo, D. J. (2005). *An Introduction to the New Testament* (Second Edition). Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan.

- J. L. **Houlden**, *The Johannine Epistles*, HNTC (San Francisco: Harper, 1973)
- E. **Käsemann**, "Ketzer und Zeuge," *ZTK* 48 (1951): 292–31l
- Hans-Josef **Klauck**, *Der erste Johannesbrief*, EKKNT 23/1 (Zürich: Benziger / Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1991)
- idem, *Der zweite und dritte Johannesbrief*, EKKNT 23/2 (Zürich: Benziger / Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1992)
- idem, "Zur rhetorischen Analyse der Johannesbriefe," *ZNW* 81 (1990): 205–24
- Colin G. **Kruse**, *The Letters of John*, PNTC (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2000)
- Robert **Law**, *The Tests of Life* (1914; reprint, Grand Rapids: Baker, 1979)
- Judith M. **Lieu**, " 'Authority to Become Children of God': A Study of 1 John," *NovT* 23 (1981): 210–28
- idem, *The Second and Third Epistles of John* (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1986)
- idem, *The Theology of the Johannine Epistles* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1991)
- Edward **Malatesta**, *Interiority and Covenant: A Study of* εἶναι ἐν *and* μένειν ἐν *in the First Letter of Saint John*, AnBib 69 (Rome: BIP, 1978)
- I. Howard **Marshall**, *The Epistles of John*, NICNT (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1978)
- W. **Nauck**, *Die Tradition und der Charakter des ersten Johannesbriefes*, WUNT 3 (Tübingen: Mohr-Siebeck, 1957)
- J. C. **O'Neill**, *The Puzzle of 1 John* (London: SPCK, 1966)
- John **Painter**, *1, 2, and 3 John*, SacPag 18 (Collegeville: Liturgical Press, 2002)
- Vern **Poythress**, "Testing for Johannine Authorship by Examining the Use of Conjunctions," *WTJ* 46 (1984): 350–69
- idem, "The Use of the Intersentence Conjunctions *De, Oun, Kai*, and Asyndeton in the Gospel of John," *NovT* 26 (1984): 312–34
- David **Rensberger**, *1 John 2 John 3 John*, ANTC (Nashville: Abingdon Press, 1997)
- W. L. **Richards**, *The Classification of the Greek Manuscripts of the Johannine Epistles*, SBLDS 35 (Missoula, Mont.: SP, 1977)
- James M. **Robinson**, ed., *The Nag Hammadi Library*, rev. ed. (San Francisco: HarperSanFrancisco, 1990)
- Rudolf **Schnackenburg**, *The Johannine Epistles: A Commentary*, 3 vols. (New York: Crossroad, 1992)
- Stephen S. **Smalley**, *1, 2, 3 John*, WBC 51 (Waco: Word, 1984)
- D. Moody **Smith**, *First, Second, and Third John*, Interpretation (Louisville: John Knox Press, 1991)
- John R. W. **Stott**, *The Letters of John*, TNTC (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1988)
- Georg **Strecker**, *The Johannine Letters*, Hermeneia (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1996 [German orig. 1989])

- Duane F. **Watson**, “1 John 2:12–14 as *Distributio, Conduplictio*, and *Expolitio:* A Rhetorical Understanding,” *JSNT* (1989): 97–110
- idem, “A Rhetorical Analysis of 2 John According to Greco-Roman Conventions,” *NTS* 35 (1989): 104–30
- idem, “A Rhetorical Analysis of 3 John: A Study in Epistolary Rhetoric,” *CBQ* 51 (1989): 479–501
- idem, “Amplification Techniques in 1 John: The Interaction of Rhetorical Style and Invention,” *JSNT* 51 (1993): 99–123
- B. F. **Westcott**, *The Epistles of St John* (1892; reprint, Appleford: Marcham Manor, 1966)
- Rodney A. **Whitacre**, *Johannine Polemic: The Role of Tradition and Theology*, SBLDS 67 (Chico: SP, 1982)
- D. Bruce **Woll**, *Johannine Christianity in Conflict*, SBLDS 60 (Chico: SP, 1981).